

Voluntary Report – Voluntary - Public Distribution

Date: July 23, 2026

Report Number: KS2026-0031

Report Name: ROK Increases Soybeans for Sprouting WTO Tariff-Rate Quota Volume

Country: Korea - Republic of

Post: Seoul

Report Category: Oilseeds and Products

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Report Highlights:

On July 13, 2026, the Republic of Korea (ROK) announced a 10,000 metric ton (MT) increase in soybean-for-sprout imports under the 2026 WTO tariff-rate quota (TRQ) voluntary add-up plan to curb rising market prices and address potential tightened supplies in the second half of the year. The additional volumes are subject to the WTO TRQ 5 percent preferential tariff rate. MAFRA clarified that these imports will not replace domestic soybeans but will instead supplement domestic production. From 2020 to 2025, the ROK imported roughly 46,000 MT annually of additional food-grade soybeans to meet domestic demand.

ROK Increases Soybeans for Sprouting WTO Tariff-Rate Quota (TRQ) Volume

On July 13, 2026, the Ministry of Agriculture, Food, and Rural Affairs (MAFRA) [announced](#) a 10,000 MT increase of soybeans for sprouting imports under the calendar year (CY) 2026 WTO TRQ voluntary add-up plan, as a proactive measure to prevent further market price increases and to address domestic supply shortfalls. The ROK will apply the 5 percent WTO in-quota tariff rate. The out-of-quota tariff rate is 487 percent, or 956 Korean won (\$0.70) per kilogram, whichever is greater. MAFRA plans to subsequently amend its 2026 TRQ operation plan, with implementation to begin in August 2026. MAFRA issued [an explanatory note](#) stating that these amounts will not replace domestic soybeans but will instead address the insufficient supplies of soybeans for sprout, which have been tight since MAFRA's December 2025 decision to eliminate the voluntary CY2026 WTO TRQ add-up for food-grade soybeans.

Each December, MAFRA announces the autonomous TRQ management plan, including any additional quotas for food-grade soybeans above the WTO minimum quantities. To promote domestic soybean consumption and reduce excess domestic soybean stocks, which exceed 120,000 MT this year, MAFRA suspended the additional annual WTO quota for 2026. From 2020 to 2025, MAFRA tendered roughly 46,000 MT on average through the add-up.

Table 1 ROK: Voluntary WTO TRQ Add-Up, 2020-2026

WTO TRQ Management for Food-grade Soybean (Metric Tons)			
CY	WTO Minimum	Voluntary Add-up	Total
2020	185,787	41,680	227,467
2021		38,335	224,122
2022		77,962	263,749
2023		45,000	230,787
2024		38,200	223,987
2025		32,966	218,753
2026		10,000 (only for soybeans for sprouting)	195,787

Source: 2020-2025: Industry Associations of Soy Food Manufacturers' Report, 2026: MAFRA press release on July 13, 2026

U.S. market share of ROK soybean for sprouting imports is typically around 13 percent. In 2025, China dominated this market, holding a 77 percent soybean-for-sprout import market share.

In contrast to soybeans for sprouting, the leading suppliers of food-grade soybeans are the United States, followed by China and Canada. From January to June 2026, however, the U.S. market share fell sharply as the Korea Agro-Fisheries and Food Trade Corporation (aT) awarded a bulk shipment under its 2026 import tender to China based on a price advantage. aT awarded all of its 2027 food-grade soybean public tenders to U.S.-origin suppliers. These tenders cover bulk shipment quantities and exclude import rights tenders. Import rights tenders represent a marginal portion of total imports under the TRQ for which importers determine the country of origin.

Table 2 ROK: Country of Origin for Food-grade Soybeans by Year

Food-grade Soybean Imports by Purpose and Origin (Metric Tons)					
By Purpose	By Country	CY2025		CY2026	YoY Change (percent)
		Full Year, Jan.-Dec.	First 6 Months, Jan.-Jun.	First 6 Months, Jan.-Jun.	
for Food (HS Code 1201.90.9000)	United States	188,889	141,980	62,045	-56%
	<i>U.S. Market Share</i>	78%	85%	49%	-36%
	China	12,874	5,843	57,504	+884%
	Canada	32,709	18,847	6,273	-67%
	Others	7,793	185	480	+159%
	Sub Total	242,265	166,855	126,302	-24%
for Sprout (HS Code 1201.90.3000)	United States	3,659	1,896	3,235	+71%
	<i>U.S. Market Share</i>	13%	14%	23%	+9%
	China	21,610	9,607	9,276	-3%
	Canada	1,738	1,680	1,388	-17%
	Others	1,150	268	0	-100%
	Sub Total	28,157	13,451	13,899	+3%
Grand Total		270,422	180,306	140,201	-22%

Source: Korea Customs Service

Import of Food-grade Soybeans with Preferential Tariff: WTO TRQ and Free Trade Agreement (FTA)

While the WTO TRQ is the main channel for food-grade soybean imports, FTAs also offer preferential access. The U.S.-Korea Free Trade Agreement (KORUS) established a zero-duty TRQ for U.S. food-grade soybeans. The KORUS food-grade soybean TRQ, which started in 2015, volume grows three percent annually in perpetuity. In CY 2026, aT allocated 35,645 MT of food-grade soybeans under the KORUS FTA for import. Australia, Canada, and China have similar food-grade soybean TRQs through their bilateral FTAs with Korea. In CY 2027, the KORUS soybean TRQs for U.S. food-grade soybeans will rise to 36,714 MT while the volume from other origins will remain the same.

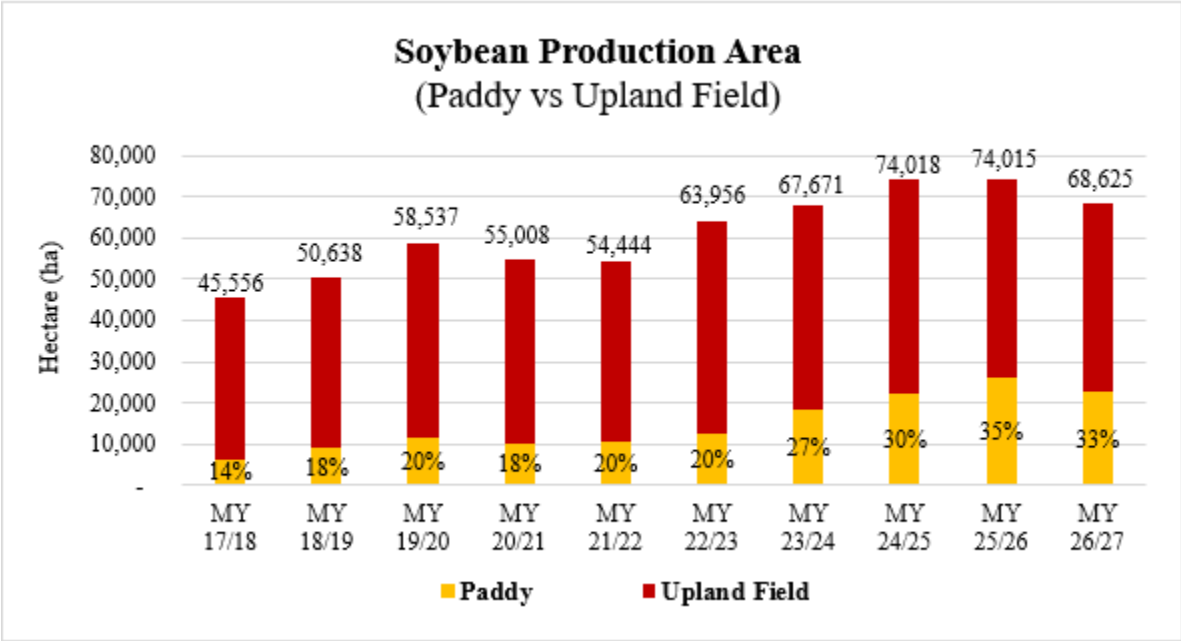
Domestic Soybean Production Promotion Through Government Purchases

According to the Korea Rural Economic Institute's (KREI) June 2026 soybean report, domestic soybean production has increased significantly in line with efforts to replace rice acreage with other crops, reaching 33 percent of total production as of marketing year (MY) 2026/27.

Soybean planting intention in MY 2026/27 declined for the first time since MY 2020/21, driven by concerns over inconsistent government purchases and weak demand. Local soybean processing industries have long relied on competitive imported soybeans for manufacturing products such as tofu and soymilk and have found difficulties substituting domestic soybeans, primarily due to the price gap. According to aT, as of CY 2025, the average price for imported soybeans for manufacturing was 1,400

Korean Won (KRW) per kg (equivalent to \$0.97), while the domestic soybean price exceeded KRW 4,100 (equivalent to \$2.8) per kg. The ROK has sought to encourage production through government purchases, however, due to high stocks, MAFRA decided to reduce its purchases of domestic soybeans this year to 30,000 MT, down from 60,000 MT last year.

Figure 1 ROK: Soybean Production by Field Type



Source: Korean Statistical Information Service, MY2026/27: planting intention survey in March 2026 by KREI
Note: Numbers above the graph indicate total production area combining paddy and upland field.

Attachments:

No Attachments.